

Episode 199: About *Revolutionary Girl Utena* – Part 1

Everyone, it's been a while.

Long Time No See.

Suddenly resuming the series!

Please support me!

Now then.

The other day I went to peek at "76th Anime Style Event: *Revolutionary Girl Utena* - Anime Magazine Editor's Adventure [Extra Edition]" held at Shinjuku Loft Plus One. Nostalgic stories like that, and stories I'd never known - quite interesting tales. Listening to Oguro-san and Nishikori-san's talk on stage, I remembered various forgotten things, so I'll write them down.

"Tsujita-san, you understand rough animation and in-between refinement, right? You can read all the timesheets, right? Hey, won't you try directing?"

That was when Ikuhara was already decided to leave Toei Animation and become independent - one dawn after I'd pulled an all-nighter at the studio for some work, Ikuhara casually came to the finishing department where I was... hmm? Was that wrong? Was it while eating breakfast in the early morning Oizumi studio cafeteria? Anyway, being suddenly told that, I panicked. Well, thinking about it now, that was probably Ikuhara inviting me to a new work he was about to start - as a director.

But I never imagined directing at the time, had no confidence, and above all the "colour" work was so enjoyable I couldn't help it. I don't remember how I responded to Ikuhara's

words, but ultimately I didn't become a director, and Ikuhara left Toei Animation as planned.

I think it was several months (?) after that happened. Ikuhara called, and we decided to meet in Nishi-Ogikubo on a Saturday. "How about food?" so the two of us went to a set meal restaurant at Nishi-Ogikubo Station's south exit. Eating set meals silently without talking much. Around when we finished eating, suddenly "I made a studio, want to come see?" Ikuhara said this abruptly, and leaving the restaurant he immediately started walking briskly toward Ogikubo direction down Shinmei-dori from the south exit. Following one step behind. We walked quite a ways down that street with sparse shops to a certain apartment building. The studio was in its basement. That was "BE-PAPAS."

The studio wasn't fully functional yet - several animation desks were installed, but there was still space for more desks to come in, with vague partition screens, and beyond that a reception set was prominently placed. I didn't look directly, but in a narrow room's dim interior there was a bunk bed with a sake bottle suddenly placed there, and I think there was a copy machine? Maybe a computer was placed there too. That kind of feeling.

BE-PAPAS studio was actually quite spacious. While showing me around that studio, "Well, we're preparing a new work here," said Ikuhara.

Ikuhara's desk was positioned with the full glass wall set up for lighting behind him, and Hasegawa's desk was about two seats away. The sofa that would later become famous among fans was already, I believe, placed behind Ikuhara's desk at that time. Such a somewhat relaxed, particular feeling.

Ah, creating an underground secret base (studio) like this and preparing to start something new - that atmosphere was so frustratingly cool.

Now, at that time Hasegawa was also in the studio, drawing rough animation for copyright stills for some work. After greeting "It's been a while!" I was shown rough

sketches of new work characters that Hasegawa had drawn. "Colours and such aren't decided yet..." - the characters I was shown were rough but sharp, cool, and somehow had wonderfully good sensuality.

So, well, somehow naturally I found myself saying "Ikuhara, can I take these characters with me?"

That's how I came to participate in that work. It was *Revolutionary Girl Utena*. Thinking about it, was I skillfully drawn in? Did I fall into Ikuhara's evil hands? No no, I got hooked on my own, quite naturally? (laugh)

At that time I was honestly getting fed up with the tendencies of work assigned at Toei Animation. I wanted to do something new, get involved in something new. For me it was exactly perfect timing.

Even if I hadn't spoken up myself at that timing, I think Ikuhara would have made such an offer anyway, and as a result I would have participated after all. It was such fate.

That was early autumn 1995, when broadcast start dates and time slots weren't even decided yet.

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